choreographed a hate campaign against philosopher Ernst Bloch in Leipzig, who was ostracised and isolated from his staff and students. By then, the outlook for opposing voices was grim. Writer and professor Alfred Kantorowicz fled into exile in Berlin, as did the Rector of Jena University, Professor Josef Hämel, and the literary scholar, Hans Mayer. Many other academics followed them. In all, Neues Deutschland reported on 1 November, seventy-three ‘agents’ had been arrested on charges relating to the security and political and economic future of the GDR. Years later, Honecker recalled when the ‘class enemy tried to get students from the Humboldt University onto the streets in Berlin at the end of October 1956; it was the working-class KDA combat groups that thwarted this intention simply by appearing.’ The KDA, a paramilitary organisation serving as the de facto militia of the SED, was composed of party members and politically reliable working people. In a speech to members, Honecker once said:

The class enemy hates the working-class combat groups in the GDR. That doesn’t bother us. He fears it. That’s a good thing and he’s right to fear it. The high level of political maturity and morale, firm discipline and boundless devotion to the cause of socialism is the guarantee that the combat groups will continue to carry out all the tasks assigned to them with honour.

[3]

But it wasn’t just academics that fell victim to the purges. With the help of Mielke, Honecker plunged energetically into the task of gathering enough evidence of dissent to have his old rival Karl Schirdewan and Stasi chief Ernst Wollweber dismissed – both held critical views of Ulbricht and sought to ‘democratise’ the SED. As his investigation intensified, Mielke installed a listening device in Wollweber’s apartment, where Schirdewan’s friends often met for a confidential exchange of views.